away, a ten-minute walk and stroll back after dinner. One night as I walked back. I realized that I had been walking for a good fifteen minutes and still had not reached the Company location. When I looked around everything was pitch black and unfamiliar. I realized soon enough that I was lost in the desert, alone, and with no idea of where the Company was. The only light was that of the Mess lantern far in the distance. I ran back to the Mess as fast as I could before that light was extinguished. After that, the compass was my constant companion.

I do believe the CO had a soft spot for me and he took me under his wing. He taught me many an important lesson that has stood me in good stead, including maturity and discretion. We had just returned from our operational area of Tanot, where the Battalion had the task of occupying a forward node. The mine-field record forms had to be prepared and submitted to the Brigade Headquarters, a task that was getting delayed. I was dispatched to the Bde HQ clutching rolls of graph paper to report to the Brigade Major, an engineer officer.[2] I did not take kindly to his 'expert' advice and pointed out some errors, which obviously didn't go down well with the BM and I was 'kindly' shown the door. I stormed out and marched into the CO's office where Col Madan Das sat serenely, reading his novel and twirling his moustache. Even as I was heatedly explaining the turn of events, the telephone rang—it was the BM—and my heart sank. After listening for a few moments, the CO remarked '*Aa das, munde ne changa kam kitta na? Sahi toh kahe ryah. Phikar na kar samjha dunga*' (Tell me; hasn't my boy done a good job? He's right. But don't worry; I'll explain it to him). Hanging up the phone and asking me to sit down, he explained the facts of Army life. 'See,' he said, 'I know you are right, the work you have produced is of high quality. The BM is my coursemate and I have placated him, but remember,

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